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Tabernacle altar

4.2.2 Tabernacle altar

References:

Hebrew מִזְבֵּחַ (mizbeach) EXO 27:1, EXO 27:1, EXO 27:5, EXO 27:5, EXO 27:6, EXO 27:7, EXO 28:43, EXO 29:12, EXO 29:12, EXO 29:13, EXO 29:16, EXO 29:18, EXO 29:20, EXO 29:21, EXO 29:25, EXO 29:36, EXO 29:37, EXO 29:37, EXO 29:37, EXO 29:38, EXO 29:44, EXO 30:18, EXO 30:20, EXO 30:28, EXO 31:9, EXO 35:16, EXO 38:1, EXO 38:3, EXO 38:4, EXO 38:7, EXO 38:30, EXO 38:30, EXO 39:39, EXO 40:6, EXO 40:7, EXO 40:10, EXO 40:10, EXO 40:10, EXO 40:29, EXO 40:30, EXO 40:32, EXO 40:33, LEV 1:5, LEV 1:7, LEV 1:8, LEV 1:9, LEV 1:11, LEV 1:11, LEV 1:12, LEV 1:13, LEV 1:15, LEV 1:15, LEV 1:15, LEV 1:16, LEV 1:17, LEV 2:2, LEV 2:8, LEV 2:9, LEV 2:12, LEV 3:2, LEV 3:5, LEV 3:8, LEV 3:11, LEV 3:13, LEV 3:16, LEV 4:7, LEV 4:10, LEV 4:18, LEV 4:18, LEV 4:19, LEV 4:25, LEV 4:25, LEV 4:26, LEV 4:30, LEV 4:30, LEV 4:31, LEV 4:34, LEV 4:34, LEV 4:35, LEV 5:9, LEV 5:9, LEV 5:12, LEV 6:2, LEV 6:2, LEV 6:3, LEV 6:3, LEV 6:5, LEV 6:6, LEV 6:7, LEV 6:8, LEV 7:2, LEV 7:5, LEV 7:31, LEV 8:11, LEV 8:11, LEV 8:15, LEV 8:15, LEV 8:15, LEV 8:16, LEV 8:19, LEV 8:21, LEV 8:24, LEV 8:28, LEV 8:30, LEV 9:7, LEV 9:8, LEV 9:9, LEV 9:9, LEV 9:10, LEV 9:12, LEV 9:13, LEV 9:14, LEV 9:17, LEV 9:18, LEV 9:20, LEV 9:24, LEV 10:12, LEV 14:20, LEV 16:12, LEV 16:18, LEV 16:18, LEV 16:20, LEV 16:25, LEV 16:33, LEV 17:6, LEV 17:11, LEV 21:23, LEV 22:22, NUM 3:26, NUM 3:31, NUM 4:13, NUM 4:14, NUM 4:26, NUM 5:25, NUM 5:26, NUM 7:1, NUM 7:10, NUM 7:10, NUM 7:11, NUM 7:84, NUM 7:88, NUM 17:3, NUM 17:4, NUM 17:11, NUM 18:3, NUM 18:5, NUM 18:7, NUM 18:17, DEU 12:27, DEU 12:27, DEU 16:21, DEU 26:4, JOS 22:29, 1SA 2:28, 1SA 2:33, 1KI 1:50, 1KI 1:51, 1KI 1:53, 1KI 2:28, 1KI 2:29, 1CH 21:29, 2CH 1:5, 2CH 1:6

References:

Rim, ledge:

Hebrew כַּרְכֹּב (karkov) EXO 27:5, EXO 38:4

Description:

The altar of the movable tabernacle (Timnah Park model) (© Ori229, CC BY-SA 3.0, via Wikimedia Commons)The Tabernacle altar was made of acacia wood overlaid, perhaps inside and out, with bronze. It measured five cubits (2.5 meters; 8.3 feet) on a side and stood three cubits (1.5 meters; 5 feet) high. Around its top was a kind of ledge or rim (*karkov* in Hebrew), the purpose of which is not given. The altar was hollow.

Translation:

See 4.2 Altars<REALIA:4.2> and 4.2.1 Stone altar<REALIA:4.2.1> above.

Rim, ledge: The Hebrew word *karkov* is found only in EXO 27:5 and EXO 38:4, and its meaning is unclear. Some scholars think of it as a decorative "rim" (GNT) around the altar that could also support the weight of the altar when lifted by the rings on the grating (EXO 27:4; see 4.2.3 Temple altar<REALIA:4.2.3> for an illustration of a rim). Others imagine that it may have been a "ledge" (RSV) wide enough for the officiating priests to stand on, but this is unlikely since the altar itself was only about 1.5 meters (5 feet) high.

It is not clear whether this rim was at the top, the middle, or the bottom of the altar. Neither is it clear whether it was on the inside or the outside of the altar. NAB translates *karkov* simply as "around," since its root meaning may have been to surround or encircle. EXO 27:5 a in NAB reads "Put it [the grating] down around the altar, on the ground."

Note that the Hebrew clause in EXO 27:5 uses both the words "under" and "below," possibly for emphasis or clarity. NJPSV has "Set the mesh below, under the ledge of the altar," and NJB says "You will put it below the ledge of the altar, underneath." Since there is so much uncertainty about the meaning of these terms, translators must choose either the idea of a "ledge" or a "rim." We may assume that it was a structural rim located probably around the top of the altar.

Grating, mesh

4.2.2.1 Grating, mesh

References:

Hebrew מִכְבָּר (mikbar) EXO 27:4, EXO 35:16, EXO 38:5, EXO 38:5, EXO 38:30, EXO 39:39

References:

Ring:

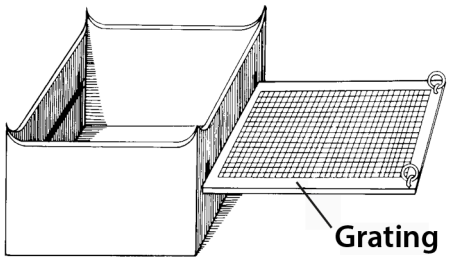
Hebrew טַבַּעַת (tabaʿath) EXO 27:4, EXO 27:7, EXO 38:5, EXO 38:7

References:

Pole:

Hebrew בַּד (bad) EXO 27:6, EXO 27:6, EXO 27:7, EXO 27:7, EXO 38:5, EXO 38:6, EXO 38:7

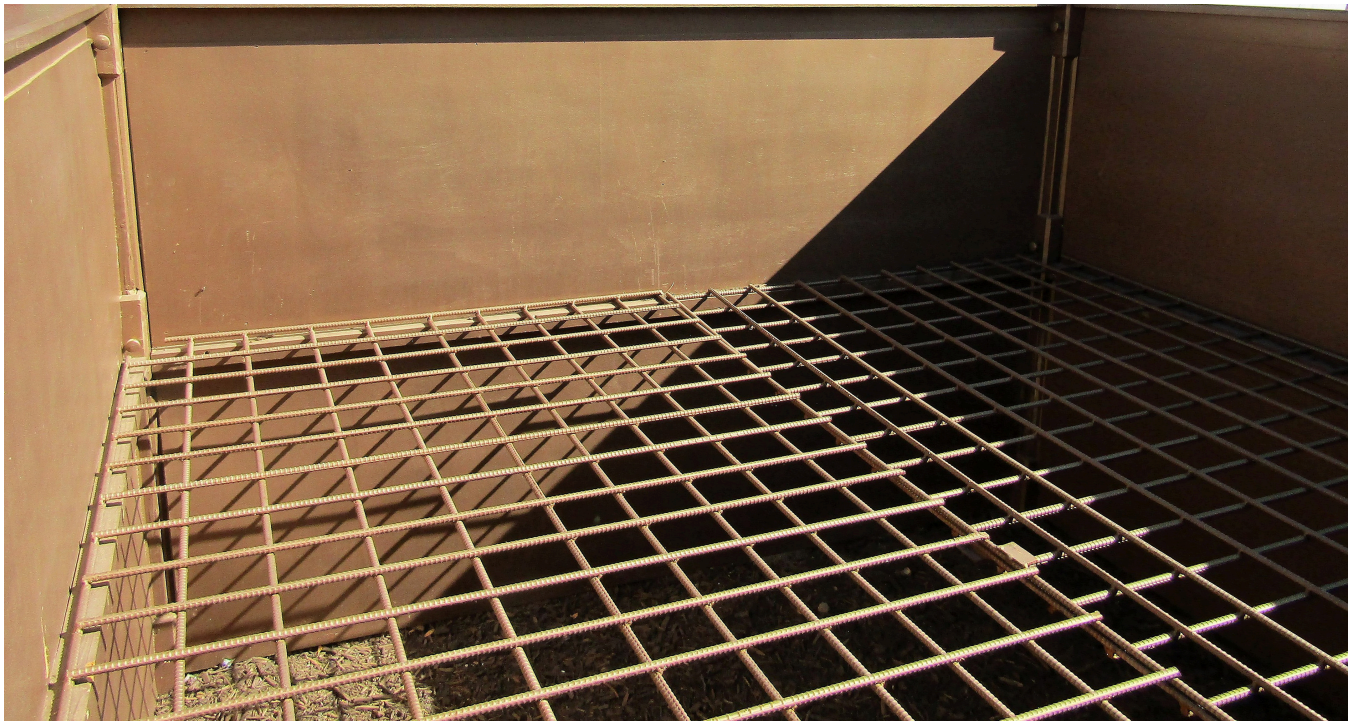
Description and usage:



Drawing of grating attached to the altar (Don Ellens, The Tabernacle of Israel, Harris, Jones 1888, Public domain)The grating of the Tabernacle altar was similar to a spider's web with a fine meshwork, except that it was made of bronze. Its purpose is not explained, but it was probably intended to hold the burning coals and allow the ashes and grease to fall through to the

ground, as well as to allow for a draft of air to pass through from underneath. Both were necessary for a hot fire. On the four upper corners of the grating were attached bronze rings. Poles were inserted through these rings for transporting the altar.

Translation:



Grating inside the altar (BYU model) (© Ben P L, CC BY 2.0, via Wikimedia Commons)The Hebrew word for grating (*mikbar*) is related to the word for "sieve" in AMO 9:9. The Hebrew phrase that describes it in EXO 27:4 is *ma'aseh resheth*, which is literally "net-work." The exact position and function of this mesh are disputed. Some scholars have suggested that it was simply wrapped around the bottom half of the altar as a decoration, perhaps also serving to strengthen the wooden frame of the altar; for example, CEV renders EXO 27:4 a as "cover the bottom half of the altar with a decorative bronze grating." Most, however, understand it as it is described above. Its placement on or in the altar was related in some way to the rim or ledge, which went around the top of the altar (see 4.2.2 Tabernacle altar<REALIA:4.2.2>).

"So that the net shall extend halfway down the altar" (EXO 27:5 b in RSV) is literally "and the net will be until half of the altar." This does not indicate whether it means halfway down or "halfway up the altar" (GNT). Most translations have "halfway up," suggesting that the grating was placed in some way at the lower half of the altar. But RSV and NRSV suggest that this grating was near the top. It is probably better for translators to follow this interpretation.

As can be seen from an overview of various translations, it is possible to translate EXO 38:4; EXO 38:5 and the parallel passage in EXO 27:4; EXO 27:7 without actually leaving the reader with a clear picture of how the grating, rim, and altar were related. While it is true that the functions of the rim and the grating are disputed, a clear description of one feasible option is to be preferred to a rendering that is meaningless to the reader. The following model is given in *A Handbook on Exodus* (page 635):

4 Make a bronze grating, like a strainer, and attach a bronze ring at each of its four corners. 5 Then place the grating under the rim that goes around the altar, so that it extends halfway down inside the altar.

Another possible model is:

5 Build a rim around the altar near the top, and hang a bronze grating from it extending halfway down inside the altar. At each of the four corners of the grating attach a bronze ring.

Rings and poles: EXO 27:4 says that bronze rings were to be put on the "ends" or "edges" of the grating. Verse 7 describes the placing of the poles into "the rings, so that the poles shall be upon the two sides of the altar" (RSV). The Hebrew seems to indicate that there is only one set of rings, those attached to the grating, and that they were used to carry the entire altar. The placement of the rings will depend on the translator's understanding of the grating as discussed above. If the "grating"

is understood as a mesh going around the outside of the altar, then the rings are simply attached to the mesh. If, on the other hand, the "grating" is understood to be horizontal and sitting inside the altar, the rings projected through the corners of the altar so that the poles could be put through them.

The poles were placed into the rings for carrying the altar, and they were probably removed after it had been set into place. Where a language distinguishes between installing an object permanently or temporarily, the latter option is the correct one here. This may mean using a different verb in EXO 27:7 from the one used in EXO 25:14 (see the discussion under 4.1 Covenant Box, Ark of the Covenant<REALIA:4.1>).